

Zambia



Bordered to the south by the Zambezi River, Zambia lies at the heart of southern Africa. In 1991, it made a peaceful transition from single-party rule to multiparty democracy.



GEOGRAPHY

A high savanna plateau, broken by mountains in northeast. Vegetation mainly trees and scrub.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with three seasons: cool and dry, hot and dry, and wet. Southwest is prone to drought.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are more than 70 different ethnic groups, but there are fewer tensions than in many African states. Major groups are the Bemba (in the northeast), Tonga (south), Nyanja (east), and Lozi (west). There are also thousands of refugees, mostly from the DRC and Angola. A National Gender Policy was issued in 2000 to redress inequalities between the sexes. The standard of living has fallen in real terms since independence. One in seven adults is infected with HIV/AIDS.



THE ECONOMY

Copper: output has risen since 2000, when decades of falling global prices ended. New agricultural exports, notably flowers. Debt relief.



INSIGHT: *Spray from Musi-o-Tunya (Victoria Falls) can be seen up to 20 miles (35 km) away*



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Zambia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1964

CAPITAL: Lusaka

POPULATION: 12.9 million

TOTAL AREA: 290,584 sq. miles
(752,614 sq. km)

DENSITY: 45 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Bemba, Tonga, Nyanja, Lozi, Lala-bisa, Nsenga, English*

RELIGIONS: Christian 63%, traditional beliefs 36%, Muslim and Hindu 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Bemba 34%, other 27%, Tonga 16%, Nyanja 14%, Lozi 9%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Zamb. kwacha = 100 ngwee